

6.6 Issues and debates	Examples of issues and debates in criminological psychology: • Ethics (e.g. effects of unreliability of jury decision-making; effects of unreliability of eye-witness testimony; using field experiments to test eye-witness unreliability with possible lack of debriefing). • Practical issues in the design and implementation of research (e.g. having to use mock juries and artificial situations because of not being able to manipulate real trial situations). • Reductionism (e.g. using experiments and field experiments to test issues around eye-witness testimony such as weapons effect; biological explanations for criminal behaviour). • Comparisons between ways of explaining behaviour using different themes (e.g. different explanations for criminal behaviour drawing on biology, learning theories and social psychology). • Psychology as a science (e.g. using experiments and field experiments; using biological explanations). • Culture and gender (e.g. as issues that might affect jury decision-making – sometimes to the detriment of the defendant). • Nature-nurture (e.g. biological versus social/learning explanations for criminal behaviour). • An understanding of how psychological understanding has developed over time (e.g. Loftus and Palmer's study of eye-witness testimony and consider Loftus's work in the field currently; cognitive interview and ethical interview). • Issues of social control (e.g. treatments and therapies for those convicted of crime or anti-social behaviour; the power of a therapist, a forensic psychologist, or the person controlling the treatment/therapy). • The use of psychological knowledge within society (e.g. warning about unreliability of eye-witness testimony; warning about issues that might affect jury decision-making). • Issues related to socially-sensitive research (e.g. looking at causes for criminal behaviour in socially sensitive areas such as socio-economic status, race, age, gender).
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